gesticulated at the hut behind him. He was quickly joined by another soldier who now raised a pair of binoculars to stare back. I was about to wave when the young Indian officer next to me enclosed my right hand: 'Don't do anything sudden. Slowly bring the binoculars down to your side.' Which I did.

This was the line on the map, where a naive sixteen-year-old schoolboy could spark a violent incident by raising his binoculars and waving to the enemy. Borders matter to all societies, and they are usually defended to the death. In the last days of 1971, I got a glimpse of what India's Himalayan borderlands really are. Wars are hell even when you are winning (as in Bangladesh); for the young men on both sides, with nothing to do in the harsh temperatures and thin air, determined to defend a line they could hardly define, this was hellish enough even if they were not at war.

The Border, Tibet, and Military Conflict, 1949–1962

The story of the India–China quarrels in the high Himalaya has three inter-related parts – their border negotiations; their interactions over Tibet; and their military worries and moves along the boundaries. It is a story spanning two broad periods of time: from 1949, when the CPC took power, to November 1962 when the India–China war ended; and from 1963 to the present. The first period is a particularly complicated story, with partisan accounts blaming one side or the other for the disputes and, in the end, for the war and subsequent rivalry. In fact, the two governments tried, and to some extent succeeded, in cooperating on the border, Tibet, and military stability before succumbing to conflict and eventually to war.

The Border

From 1949 to the outbreak of war on 20 October 1962, India and China tried to settle their differences over the border. Much of the writing on the period suggests one side or the other was determined to stick to its view of